> even India, though it has left his doctrine, preserve the tradition of his greatness. More living men cherish his memory today than ever heard the names of Constantine or Charlemagne.[6]

But, above all, Ashoka stands out because his story is, to a considerable extent, preserved in his own words. This was nicely articulated by Jawaharlal Nehru in his *The Discovery of India* when he said that in their magnificent language Ashoka's edicts spoke to him of a 'a man who though, an emperor, was greater than any king or emperor.'[7] Nehru, like Ashoka, was for many years the unquestioned ruler of an Indian territory roughly the same size; more important, he followed Ashoka in being his own 'sutradhar' (narrator).

Ashoka naturally also figures in many ancient chronicles, even if not in those by his contemporaries. He appears in writings that were put together several centuries after his reign, ranging from the Sanskrit text *Ashokavadana* (*c*. second century CE) to the Sri Lankan Pali chronicles like the *Dipavamsa* (*c*. fourth century CE) and the *Mahavamsa* (*c*. fifth century CE). These will figure at different points in this story of Ashoka because such writings shape our understanding of his early years as prince and monarch, even as we bear in mind that their reliability as sources of biographical information is uncorroborated by anything written during or even close to his own time. The reliability of historical detail in such texts, though, can be assessed by juxtaposing them with what can be reconstructed about those times through archaeological evidence. This is perhaps one of the defining differences between monarchs of very ancient times on the one hand, and those of medieval and later times on the other. Of Akbar and some of the other major Mughals, for instance, we arrive at a picture via works by their contemporaries. And at least three of the close collaborators of Sultan Saladin (1137/38–1193 CE)—the iconic Muslim ruler whose name is associated with the Crusades (especially with the recapture of Jerusalem from European Crusaders in 1187 CE)—penned accounts of his life and reign, each providing direct testimony of the ruler.[8]